A RAFT OF NEW LEAGUES

GOLF AND VOLLEYBALL, EVEN ARM WRESTLING AND PICKLEBALL, ARE BEING PACKAGED INTO FRANCHISE-BASED LEAGUES. NOT ONLY DO THEY HELP ATHLETES HONE SKILLS, THEY CAN OVERHAUL SPORTING ECOSYSTEMS

BY SUHANI SINGH





AIMING HIGH Clockwise from left: an archer in the final of the Archery Premier League, Oct. 13; action from the final of Prime Volleyball League, Oct. 26; a match at the Pro Panja League, 2023 and a daring move in a Ultimate Kho Kho match in 2023

Once upon a time and not too long ago, sports channels were dyed in cricket, and more cricket. When it wasn't live telecast of a Men in Blue series, they beamed endless reruns of India's memorable victories, or other nations on tour. Then there was two months of the Indian Premier League and replays thereof. But how swiftly times have changed! Broadcasters suddenly have more options as sports associations team up with companies, private investors and even Bollywood stars to package different sports into highly competitive leagues. In the past few years, India has seen new leagues of badminton, table tennis, kho kho and volleyball, besides popular ones like kabaddi, hockey and football. This year has seen launches of leagues in archery and pickleball alongside announcements of those in golf and shooting. And it's not just audiences who get variety